

popular fish varieties, that is bearing the brunt. Already endangered, the species may well disappear in a few decades if no concrete steps are taken by the government. According to the government fisheries department at the Centre, Hilsa Toli, commonly known as Mukhpura Ilish, is already extinct. The state Government of course sees no immediate danger. Principal Secretary, fisheries, Rachpal Kahlol says that his department is conducting routine tests but did not find anything alarming. "But we welcome the PETA initiative and would love to assess the report and take action if necessary," he says.

Apart from industry effluents that are a major water polluter, small particulates like dental fillings could be a factor too. Silver amalgamation modules, the most common fillings, contain huge quantities of mercury which finally make its way to sewage. The disposal figure nationwide has been put at 300 kg annually, a huge amount, considering the toxicity of mercury. However, most dentists in Kolkata have now discontinued the practice of using silver amalgamations though in the mofussils and towns, it is still a rampant practice. "Mercury is one of the most dangerous environment pollutants. Even when a thermometer breaks, there is a high risk but not too many people are aware of the long-term dangers. When mercury is released into the environment, it gets transformed into methylated mercury which settles in water bodies, enters fish and consequently the human body once the fish is eaten. It is the root cause of nervous disorders, memory loss, long-term brain damage and pre-natal complications," says Chacrevarti.

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NIKHUNJ SHARMA

SENIOR CAMPAIGN COORDINATOR, PETA INDIA

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A FISHERMAN CASTS HIS NET IN THE DAMODAR; A FISH CAUGHT AT SEA (BELOW)

KAUSHIK



INDIA IS THE WORLD'S THIRD LARGEST PRODUCER OF FISH WITH AN ANNUAL PRODUCTION OF 6.3 MILLION TONNES.

PETA is now going all out with its campaign to stop the consumption of contaminated fish in Bengal. "We know it may sound alarmist but laboratory tests have conclusively proved mercury contamination in most fish in Bengal. The only way is to turn vegetarian," says senior campaign coordinator of PETA India, Nikhunj Sharma.

A round of the fishmongers in the upmarket Gariahat Bazaar in south Kolkata revealed that fish sellers are aware of the problem but are unwilling to warn customers. "We have heard about the contamination but this is our livelihood and we cannot go about asking people not to buy fish," says Gopeswar Sarkar, who has been selling Hilsa for the last 34 years. Even doctors are hesitant about pinning down fish eating as the cause of most nervous and brain disorders. "There is a lack of awareness

and it is a fact that mercury is a killer. Also, it takes a long time for mercury contamination to show side-effects. So it goes unnoticed. But I will definitely not recommend people to stop eating fish as it is high in protein and cannot be abandoned. The Government instead should take measures to stop mercury contamination of water bodies," says physician S. Kaseria.

However, with alarm bells ringing, it is high time the Government began regulating fishing practices in the state. Fishing on the coastline is indiscriminate and according to environmental experts, seabed is the worst affected because of "bottom trawling" where it is savaged by massive dragging nets with metal plates. Also, there are no periodic intervals to allow the fish to breed and recoup their numbers.

Nevertheless, fish-eating continues to rule. It is still the most sought-after delicacy by tourists in West Bengal and as Gautam Kapoor, restaurateur, says, fish will continue to be the king. "We have chefs who can see through fish as it were. Anything slightly suspicious is rejected immediately. We do not use rotten stuff," says Kapoor. That confidence could be misplaced. ■

